

The Magic of Saffron: A Crop of Gold in the Streets of Pune!

The magic of saffron in the streets of Pune!

Saffron, one of the most expensive spices in the world, which is also called the "gold crop", is now being grown in the streets of Pune city. Amidst the hustle and bustle of Pune city and the noise of traffic, saffron is being cultivated without soil in a simple-looking container. This is a living example of the advanced farming happening in India.

Shailesh: Journey from code to container!

Shailesh Modak, who was once a software engineer, made a unique beginning in the field of agriculture in the year 2018. First, he gained experience from businesses like beekeeping and import-export. After this, he got the idea of growing "saffron", one of the most expensive spices in the world, in a controlled environment. With the help of one of his doctor friends, he started soil-less cultivation in a simple-looking container.

Container becomes mini Kashmir: the wonder of high-tech farming!

Shailesh Modak converted an 8×40 feet iron container into his farm. This was no ordinary farm – in fact, it had no soil, no cocopit, no sunlight and no hydroponic technique. He brought 600 kg of corm/bulb from Pampore (Kashmir) and placed 500 kg of corm/bulb in a tray. The red-blue LED became the sun, generated the cold of Kashmir with the help of a chiller and controlled everything with automation. This small Pampore of Kashmir was ready.

Tiny purple flowers: More expensive than gold!

The bulbs were placed vertically, which saved more space in the container. In the season of September-October, 1 to 3 tiny purple flowers come out of each bulb, which costs ₹500-₹700 per gram.

Saffron blooms with technology: the magic of smart farming!

Red and blue LEDs supplement the sunlight, which helps in photosynthesis. Carbon dioxide control and humidity equipment help in balancing the air. With the help of the chiller system and air conditioning, the temperature is maintained between 15°C and 25°C, which is required

for saffron. They have used motion cameras, which send messages on Shailendra's phone about the status of the container.

Cost and Profit: Economics of Container Farming!

He said that the cost of setting up this setup was 9 lakhs, out of which 6 lakhs were spent on buying bulbs. But he was successful in getting more than 870 grams of saffron from 500 kg bulbs. In one harvest, he sold saffron worth more than 4 lakhs through B2B. He also said that from one corm, he can get continuous production for 7-8 years.

Saag with saffron: multipurpose farming!

Modak ji is not limited to saffron only. He is also growing leafy vegetables like Lollo Rosso. In which he saves up to 95% water as compared to traditional farming. 4000 plants consume only 40 litres of water per day. For nutrients, he installed a recycling tank, which is reused.

If not controlled, flowers will be lost!

Shailesh says that if the temperature and humidity are not maintained properly, the flowers do not bloom properly or wither.

Darker than Kashmiri: Pune's saffron!

His saffron is darker than Kashmiri saffron. When put in water, it does not release colour immediately but releases it slowly. Its taste is bitter, and the fragrance is very strong.

Keeping pace with the environment: container farming!

Shailesh's container farming not only solves the problem of space, but it is also environmentally friendly. In this, more production can be taken in less space, with less water, and in a controlled environment. Keeping in mind the changing weather, this is the future of farming. High-value plants are planted in it, and more and more profits can be earned.

Source:

<https://youtu.be/8amybzcq68o?si=ov6phs4YvJ6TLAZI>